

The Internet is nothing but a network of networks, a Web of computers linked to each other all over the whole wide world (that is not what “www” stands for!) This chapter will tell you just what you’ll have to do to access the Web.

Checking out Web sites is sometimes called “surfing.” Before you start surfing, you will, naturally, need a surfboard—in this case, an ISP (Internet Service Provider).

1.1 Internet Service Providers

1.1.1 What Is An ISP?

ISPs are sometimes also referred to as Internet Access Providers (IAP). An Internet Service Provider is an organisation that provides access to the Internet and related services.

An ISP might provide dial-up access, a cable connection, an ADSL connection, or other type of Internet access. In India, there are more than 150 ISPs (including Icenet, BSNL, Airtel, 24Online, and You Telecom).

1.1.2 Kinds Of Connections

ISPs provide different kinds of connections which allow you to access the Internet, each of which has advantages and drawbacks.

a) Dialup accounts:

This is the slowest kind of connection currently available. Also, your telephone line stays in use until you terminate the connection, implying that if your telephone bill is calculated according to the time of use, you’re going to have one hefty bill coming at you at the end of the month.

Dialup means you won’t really be able to do audio/video downloads unless you have the patience of Sisyphus. Even images can take a lot of time to be downloaded (remember that Web pages are getting prettier and more image-heavy).

Today, a dialup service is the resort of a desperate customer, who has by and large no other means of connecting to the Web.